

switch cards. The hidden moral: Rebecca, like all card surfers, should stop wasting her time and pay off her debt once and for all.

- **Stability.** Some issuers want to see that you've been at your job for at least a year. It also helps if you've lived in the same apartment or house for a year.
- **Moderate usage.** To measure credit card use, issuers look at the ratio of your outstanding debt to your potential debt (that's the sum of the credit limits on all your cards). This is called your **usage ratio**. For example, if you have two cards with a combined \$1,000 credit limit and outstanding debt of \$900, your usage ratio is 90% (\$900 divided by \$1,000). This ratio should not exceed 30%. Borrowers who qualify for the best cards have a ratio of about 7%.
- **Long-term dependability.** Lenders favor borrowers who have established a lengthy track record of on-time payment—years and years of good behavior.

For the most comprehensive list of long-lasting low-rate and teaser deals, go to www.credit.com. Sites like www.cardtrak.com and www.lowcards.com also have a mix of advice and card offers. If you belong to a credit union, national association, or labor union, you might be able to get a card with a relatively low rate through one of those organizations. Also investigate local banks, which sometimes offer lower rates on cards than large national institutions do.

Pointers for Those Who Carry a Balance

About six out of every ten credit card users carry a balance from month to month. While your goal is to pay off your credit card debt entirely, until you can, take note of the following suggestions:

- **Pay your bill the day you get it.** Most credit cards have a grace period, which begins the day your purchases are made or posted (officially recorded) and lasts until the due date